The White House Years

WAGING PEACE

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Dwight D. Eisenhower

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CHAPTER XII

The Troubled Islands Again—Quemoy and Matsu, 1958

We are in for a long, hard struggle to protect what is left of the free world from further encroachment. But we can win it and we will win it unless we are stupid enough to listen to the counsel of supercaution from those who say we can't afford to arm ourselves for modern war or to help arm our allies.

—*George E. Allen*

Concessions to despotism lead inevitably to a "point of no return. . . ."

—*John Foster Dulles*

In early August 1958, while the Lebanon issue was being debated in the United Nations, the Communists made their next provocative move. This time they stepped up their belligerencies against islands off the Chinese mainland, the Quemoy and Matsu groups.[1] The Red Chinese had not seriously challenged these Chinese Nationalist-held islands since the crisis four years before that had brought on our Far East Resolution of January 1955.

The first definite word that the Chinese Communists might again try to seize the offshore islands came to me through intelligence sources on the 6th of August. Their broadcasts had become increasingly shrill. They had been building up military strength locally. Over the Formosa Strait, Sabre jets of the Chinese Nationalist Air Force began encountering Soviet-built MIGs with more frequency.

This information was given to me one day after Mr. Khrushchev had

[1] Map "The Quemoy and Matsu Island Groups," appears following page 360.

announced his refusal to attend a projected summit meeting within the framework of the United Nations Security Council. The Soviet Premier had just returned from a visit to Communist China. What relationship if any there was between the news from the Far East and his conferences with Mao Tse-tung was an intriguing subject for conjecture.

Why, we wondered, were they choosing this moment to stir up trouble in the Far East? Was Khrushchev still trying to hold Mao back, as some believed, or was he urging him on? For my part, I was quite sure that, to disturb and divide the Free World, Khrushchev would never fail to suggest dark and dangerous possibilities whenever he had an excuse.

One possibility we considered was that he may have been rankled because we had ignored his threats on Lebanon, and had concluded that a reopening of the offshore island issue might divert the attention of the world from Lebanon to the Far East and show that the Communists were still on the offensive. Perhaps he thought that the Far East would be a good place once again to test Western unity and resolve—a place where, in the light of divergent viewpoints among Western allies, the Communists might exploit apprehensions regarding Soviet advances in weaponry.

In the stridency of Mao's public boasts and threats to seize Formosa by force, this new challenge resembled the earlier one of 1955. But the current situation included new dangers that seemed to make our position more difficult, and in the days following we assessed the current circumstances.

For one thing, the Soviets had used the intervening years to build up their nuclear striking force, which now included a more formidable arsenal of hydrogen weapons. I did not doubt our total superiority, but any large-scale conflict stimulated here was now less likely to remain limited to a conventional use of power. At the same time the Communists had built a complex of military airfields in the Fukien area near the coast that would enable them to launch air attacks not only against the tiny offshore islands but against the main Chinese Nationalist base on Formosa as well. Extensive artillery emplacements now almost ringed Quemoy.

Chiang Kai-shek had helped complicate the problem. Ignoring our military advice, he had for many months been adding personnel to the Quemoy and Matsu garrisons, moving them forward, nearer the mainland. By the summer of 1958, a hundred thousand men, a third of his total ground forces, were stationed on those two island groups. From a sensible military viewpoint, those little islands should have been organized and defended only as strong outposts, with the permissible minimum in personnel strength. However, Chiang had always insisted that the loss of the offshore islands would inevitably mean the loss of Formosa itself.

It seemed likely that his heavy deployment to these forward positions was designed to convince us that he was as committed to the defense of the offshore islands as he was to that of Formosa.

But with the gauntlet thrown down, we prepared to react—and the nature of our reaction would be determined by the nature of the Reds' next move.

We had to consider that the Chinese Communists might attempt to starve out the offshore islands by blockade. There was also the possibility of an amphibious assault against the offshore islands, against Formosa, or against both. There was the likelihood that they might employ air forces to strike the Nationalists' airfields on Formosa. The Joint Chiefs of Staff thought they would.

We assumed that under the circumstances of the moment, we would probably have to come to the aid of our ally, Chiang, no matter where an assault occurred. If the assault were directed toward Formosa, our assistance would be full-out. To save the offshore islands against a first phase attack limited initially to those islands alone, a lesser response would be required and would conform to the terms of the Formosa Resolution.

While the Formosa Resolution proclaimed an American determination to defend that island and the neighboring Pescadores, an attack on the offshore islands would justify our military participation only if, I, as President, should judge the attack to be a preliminary to an assault on Formosa.

It was quite possible, of course, that the current threat to Formosa had long been planned by the Chinese Communists with the support of the Soviet Union, constituting only a part of an intermittent but continuing campaign to drive the United States out of the Far East. If the capture of the offshore islands should, in fact, lead to the loss of Formosa, the future security of Japan, the Philippines, Thailand, Vietnam, and even Okinawa would be placed in jeopardy and United States vital interests would suffer severely. Such a chain of disaster would not be wrought instantaneously, perhaps, but assuming success in the initial blow, disintegration would follow, we thought, within the course of several years. This modern possibility that "for want of a nail, a shoe was lost" had led to reaffirmation of the conclusion that Quemoy and Matsu were essential to America's security. Moreover, the Communist threats and propaganda were never directed primarily to these two small island groups; rather, the announced objective was Formosa.

We concluded that if the Reds became convinced that the United States would avoid intervention they would in all likelihood launch an amphibious assault against Quemoy and possibly Matsu. On the other

hand if the Communists were convinced that we would come to the aid of Quemoy, they would probably refrain from outright attack, confining their actions, at least initially, to blockade and interdiction tactics.

For our part, once we had intervened with major military force to save Quemoy, we would accept nothing less than victory; only in this way could we maintain the confidence of the Free World. We recognized, however, that to be successful we might face the necessity of using small-yield atomic weapons against hostile airfields, for from vastly dispersed locations, enemy bombers could concentrate their lethality on the target area of Formosa, the Pescadores, and the offshore islands. This immense geographical advantage, extremely difficult if not impossible to eliminate with conventional weapons, would have to be offset by our sheer power. The use of even small atomic bombs could scarcely fail to result, for a while, in a worldwide feeling of revulsion against the United States, a feeling which might be lessened if these relatively small weapons were used solely against military installations, minimizing fallout and civilian casualties. However, having recognized the possible necessity of such future use, there was no compulsion upon me to make an immediate decision. We felt also, if the issue could be decided quickly, the consequences on world opinion of decisive, successful action by the United States would certainly be less damaging than the political disasters caused by failure. This line of reasoning was spelled out in detail in a memorandum that Secretary Dulles and I studied, edited, and agreed on, to insure that there was no discrepancy in our thinking [see Appendix O].

However, I was determined that by every possible means we should avoid expanding hostilities more than absolutely necessary. I was by no means convinced that the Chinese Communists would be willing to risk war with us; I doubted that they would bomb the airfields on Formosa as part of a limited attack on Quemoy.

After considering all the possibilities and probable consequences, my directive was this: If we were forced to intervene to save the offshore islands—and even if I had concluded that the true objective of the attack was Formosa—we initially would restrict our air strikes to shipping and to the nearby Communist airfields. We would not launch an immediate attack on the interior of China as a "punishing" operation. The intensity, scope, and effectiveness of the Communist attack as it developed would, of course, influence my later decisions.

When these possibilities were first discussed, disagreement arose among my associates about putting out an immediate, strong statement of United States intentions. I knew that Foster Dulles, who was absent at the time, was much in favor of it. But in this instance I thought that the Joint Chiefs of Staff, who felt it wiser to "keep the Communists guessing" for

the moment, were correct. A reason for so doing was the difficulty of defining in advance—and thus limiting—what we might do. We could not say that we would defend with the power of the United States every protruding rock that was claimed by the Nationalists as an "offshore island." On the other hand, if we specified exactly what islands we would defend, we simply invited the Reds to occupy all the others of those groups.

Also, the effect on Chiang Kai-shek of a definitive statement might be undesirable. He was a proud, sometimes stubborn, sovereign ruler, and our ally. Though he derived the bulk of his war-making capabilities from us, he had a right to expect our ready assistance under appropriate conditions. But to restrain him from his cherished ambition of aggressive action against the mainland was not always easy. One way of inducing some caution on his part was to keep some doubt in his mind as to the conditions under which the United States would support him. Normally he was cooperative; now he was reportedly restless and uneasy. Under these circumstances a statement of unqualified support could encourage him to attack. A statement expressing less would be harmful to him and helpful to the enemy.

Therefore, at the moment nothing was put out. Chiang became increasingly uneasy. To try to reassure him, indirectly, Foster and I on August 23 made use of a letter from the Chairman of the House Foreign Affairs Committee to Secretary Dulles as an excuse for Foster to issue the following, which we made certain was well-publicized:

> Dear Mr. Chairman:
>
> I have received your letter of August 22.
>
> We are, indeed, disturbed by the evidence of Chinese Communist buildup, to which you refer. It suggests that they might be tempted to try to seize forcibly the Quemoy or Matsu Islands.
>
> As you know, these islands have been continuously in the hands of the Republic of China, and over the last four years the ties between these islands and Formosa have become closer and their interdependence has increased.

Then, the letter came to the key statement:

> It would be highly hazardous for anyone to assume that if the Chinese Communists were to attempt to change this situation by attacking and seeking to conquer these islands that this act could be considered or held to a "limited operation."
>
> It would, I fear, constitute a threat to the peace of the area. Therefore, I hope and believe that it will not happen.

That same day, the Chinese Communists initiated a massive artillery bombardment of the offshore islands, firing twenty thousand rounds.

From then on the Communists continued to fire about eight thousand rounds a day, causing no extensive physical damage to the fortifications, but inflicting casualties among both the military and the civilian populations. Quemoy was strafed and the Reds sent out fighter planes in strength. In addition the Communists set up a blockade which for two weeks prevented the Nationalists from convoying supplies to the islands.

Nevertheless, Chinese Nationalist morale, for the moment, was said to be high. I now ordered certain limited supporting measures. The United States Seventh Fleet was directed to take a position where it could quickly intervene in the defense of Formosa. We reinforced the fleet's carrier strength from two to four.[2] All United States forces in the area were to be placed on a "readiness alert," prepared for immediate war operations. The number of destroyers patrolling the Formosa Strait was to be augmented, as were the United States Air Defense forces on Formosa. United States forces were directed to be ready to escort Nationalist Chinese resupply vessels to the offshore islands.

These movements were not secret; in fact, to insure that they were noticed, I instructed the Department of Defense to permit a few revealing words to reach the press. These would not escape the notice of the Communists.

Under ideal circumstances, I would have preferred that the Seventh Fleet merely patrol the Formosa Strait rather than provide escorts for convoys. However, on Admiral Burke's information that the Chinese Nationalist naval forces were not sufficiently strong and experienced to give assurance that they could resupply the islands without our help, I assented to this, with the proviso that United States vessels should halt three miles off the unloading beaches, remaining in international waters. In this way we hoped to provide protection for most of the journey from Formosa, while avoiding clashes with the Communists within their territorial waters. On Sunday, September 7, the first daylight convoy from Taiwan to Quemoy went through, escorted by American ships headed

[2] The carriers *Hancock* and *Lexington* were already on hand. One of the carriers brought in to reinforce (the *Essex*) came from the Mediterranean. (As an example of the intricacy of our diplomatic problems, we found it necessary to notify President Nasser, through our Ambassador, of the movement of this carrier, assuring him that it was not being transferred to the Persian Gulf area which he would interpret as a hostile gesture.)

by the heavy cruiser *Helena* (on which I had returned from Korea in 1952).

More than a week earlier Allen Dulles had reported that the Communist radio had begun new and violent broadcasts calling for the surrender of Quemoy, and announcing that they would "liberate" Formosa. This announcement worked to our advantage. If the Reds were to attack the offshore island as a declared preliminary to moving against Formosa, their intentions would be on record, and under the Formosa Doctrine we could instantaneously come to the tactical aid of the Nationalists. Accordingly, I asked Allen Dulles to contact the Secretary of State and arrange for the State Department to make public these Communist broadcasts [see Appendix P].

A few days after the heavy shelling began I received a frantic letter from President Chiang. Much of the information on which he based his apprehensions differed markedly from that provided by our intelligence services. His version of the effectiveness of the Communist artillery bombardments on the Quemoy garrison surpassed anything that had been reported to me. He mentioned the recent loss of three Nationalist general officers and described in anguished terms the effects of Communist Chinese air and naval attacks.[3] He feared that communication between Formosa and the offshore islands would be cut any time and, surprisingly, questioned the capability of the Seventh Fleet to control the Formosa Strait. The fact that Quemoy was hemmed in by hostile artillery batteries on the east, west, and north, meant to him that unless the Nationalists were permitted to take aggressive actions on an extensive scale, Quemoy and Matsu would fall to the enemy because of starvation.

The Generalissimo asked for a categorical statement of an intention to employ our full military power to defend Quemoy and Matsu, to provide convoys for Nationalist shipping all the way from Formosa to the beaches, and to delegate to Vice Admiral Roland N. Smoot, the Commander of the Taiwan Defense Command, authority to employ United States forces to defeat any Red attack without reference to Washington.

Sympathetic as I was with the Generalissimo's general intentions, I was puzzled by much of what he wrote. His present concern over Quemoy's vulnerability to blockade seemed totally inconsistent with his earlier insistence on loading down the offshore islands with far more troops than

[3] A week later it was reported that the Generalissimo was shown detailed analyses of the Nationalist-Communist artillery duel on Quemoy. It turned out that the damage on Quemoy had been remarkably light and troop morale was high. The Commander of the Taiwan Defense Command believed that this was the first time the Generalissimo had been given a clear picture of the situation.

were necessary for defensive purposes. Naturally, I disagreed with his lack of confidence in the capabilities of the Seventh Fleet and suggested that if the Nationalists were more active in firing counterbattery on Red artillery positions the situation would look better.

I thought our military arrangements were satisfactory. The blockade of Quemoy had not yet been broken, but we were optimistic. Furthermore, in view of the efficient communications available between Taipei and Washington, I saw no need to delegate to any subordinates my authority as Commander-in-Chief to commit United States forces to action.[4]

To allay the Generalissimo's concern, however, as well as to make our position clear before the world, I approved a statement by John Foster Dulles on September 4, 1958. It presented our arguments in support of Chiang Kai-shek's legal position on Quemoy and Matsu and repeated our determination that these territories not be seized by force. The statement repeated the portion of the Formosa Doctrine that authorized the President to employ the armed forces of the United States for the protection of Taiwan and related positions and announced that

> . . . the President has not yet made any finding under that Resolution that the employment of the Armed Forces of the United States is required or appropriate in insuring the defense of Formosa. The President would not, however, hesitate to make such a finding if he judged that the circumstances made this necessary to accomplish the purposes of the Joint Resolution. In this connection, we have recognized that the securing and protecting of Quemoy and Matsu have increasingly become related to the defense of Taiwan (Formosa). . . . Military dispositions have been made by the United States so that a Presidential determination if made, would be followed by action both timely and effective.

In order to keep the door for negotiations open, however, we included the following paragraph:

> The United States has not, however, abandoned hope that Peiping will stop short of defying the will of mankind for peace. This would not require

[4] Throughout this whole period it seems that I was continually pressured—almost hounded—by Chiang on one side and by our own military on the other requesting delegation of authority for immediate action to United States commanders on the spot in the case of attack on Formosa or the offshore islands. On September 6, a request came from the Joint Chiefs of Staff asking authority for the United States Air Force to support the Chinese National Air Force in the event of a major landing attack on the offshore islands. In potentially explosive situations and with attendant communications only vaguely understood, such delegations were at times necessary. But for this case I insisted that I would assess developments as they occurred. Therefore, I kept to myself the decision to employ U.S. forces.

it to abandon its claims, however ill-founded we may deem them to be . . . . at Geneva between 1955 and 1958, a sustained effort was made by the United States to secure, with particular reference to the Taiwan area, a declaration [from Red China] of mutual and reciprocal renunciation of force, except in self-defense, which, however, would be without prejudice to the pursuit of policies by peaceful means. The Chinese Communists rejected any such declaration. We believe, however, that such a course of conduct constitutes the only civilized and acceptable procedure. The United States intends to follow that course, so far as it is concerned, unless and until the Chinese Communists, by their acts, leave us no choice but to react in defense of the principles to which all peace-loving governments are dedicated.

Two days later, September 6, I learned that Chou En-lai, the Red Chinese Premier, had just said over the radio that the Chinese were accepting our proposal, made on July 28, to resume ambassadorial talks in Warsaw, Poland, between the Communist Chinese ambassador and our own, Jacob D. Beam. These talks, after having gone on for three long years, had been suspended on June 30.

I made public the gist of the Communist broadcast and said that if the Chinese Communists were now prepared to respond constructively to our policy announcement of September 4, we would welcome such action. We assured our Nationalist ally, however, that we would not, in these talks, be a party to any arrangement that would prejudice the rights of the Republic of China. This was the first sign of a lessening of the crisis.

Our method was hardly blessed with unanimity of opinion. Harold Macmillan, for example (replying to a letter Foster had written on September 4 at my behest), quoted Winston Churchill's statement during the 1954–55 crisis: "A war to keep the coastal islands for Chiang would not be defensible" in Britain.[5]

Even more remarkable, the Defense Department now seemed willing to shift its position. On the afternoon of September 11, only a few hours before I was to deliver a televised report to the nation, the Secretary of Defense, Neil McElroy, informed me that the Joint Chiefs of Staff now felt the Quemoy and Matsu islands should be vacated (or lightly manned as outposts only). From a military standpoint alone, the latter solution had

[5] Harold Macmillan summarized the rather negative attitudes that he anticipated from the various Commonwealth countries, including Britain. Harold suggested a demilitarization of the offshore islands (a thought that he attributed to Foster Dulles). The idea he felt might be advanced by the British government either in the UN or in a separate approach to the Soviets. He did not hold out hope that our September 4 statement would induce the Communist Chinese to confine their actions to bombardment of the islands.

long been desirable, but Mr. McElroy now felt that Chiang's refusal to do so was a reflection of his hope of promoting a fight between the United States and the Chinese Communists as a prelude to a Chinese Nationalist invasion of the mainland.

To add to the afternoon's events, Foster delivered to me a report from our ambassador on Formosa that the Chinese Nationalists, fearful of our talks in Warsaw, and apprehensive over difficulties the convoys were getting into, were experiencing a severe case of jitters.

In my televised report that evening I spoke of the bombardment, of the Chinese Communist naval craft which were trying to break up the supply of Quemoy, of the fact that over one thousand people had been killed or wounded, in large part civilians. In 1955, I recalled, the Reds had broken off their attack on the offshore islands when we moved to support Free China. We had hoped they would act peacefully but now that they were not, we were bound by our treaties, and our principles, and authorized to act by the Formosa Resolution. There would be no retreat.[6] The security of the western Pacific was essential but we were there not just to save the islands but also to demonstrate that force should not be used for aggressive purposes in the modern world. "There is not going to be any appeasement," I said, and "I believe there is not going to be any war."

I had repeatedly sought to make our position clear so that there would be no danger of Communist miscalculation—but I also interpreted the congressional Joint Resolution backing up the Formosa Doctrine as requiring me not to make absolute advance commitments, covering every contingency, but to use my judgment according to the circumstances of the time. I expressed hope that the reopened Warsaw talks could find measures to resolve the problem.

Reaction to these statements was mixed. The press reported that Republicans stood behind me. Many Democrats applauded my expressed preference for peaceful negotiations over war but argued that the defense of Quemoy was not necessary to the defense of Formosa.

[6] A letter just received from Mr. Khrushchev was mentioned in this report and two days later I answered it, saying in part:

"I agree with you that a dangerous situation exists in the Taiwan area. I do not agree with you as to the source of danger. . . .

". . . United States military forces operate in the Taiwan area in fulfillment of treaty commitments to the Republic of China. . . . They are there to help resist aggression—not to commit aggression. No upside down presentation such as contained in your letter can change this fact."

I concluded with regret that I could not find in his letter any effort to find that common language which would remove the danger or that he had not written a similar letter to the Chinese Communists urging moderation. But I suggested that he encourage them toward negotiation as a civilized method of advancing one's views.

One senator declared, "The United States is being dragged into war through the back door by a dictator, a Chinese war lord who was driven off the mainland of China."

Abroad, our allies, not unexpectedly, emphasized the part of the talk that called for negotiation, rather than the sections that proclaimed the firmness of our stand. On Formosa, the country most affected, the talk, reportedly, was well received. However, a few days later the Chinese National Assembly issued an extraordinary statement saying ". . . we wish solemnly [to] advise our American ally that [the] government of the Republic of China, as [the] duly constituted government of [the] Chinese people in accordance with [the] constitution, will not tolerate any commitments reached which are detrimental to legal interests and status of [the] Chinese Republic. . . . Furthermore, we also wish [to] sound [a] solemn warning to any countries which attempt to trade our vested interests to appease Reds. . . ."

* * *

But while speeches were made, statements issued, and resolutions passed, the crisis was really eased by the success of the Nationalist Navy, with the help of United States advisers, in defeating the Red interdiction of Quemoy. For many days, almost throughout September, we had watched with keen interest this rather tiny military action.

That first convoy movement in which United States vessels participated was on September 7 and it had consisted of escort ships and two medium landing ships (LSM) carrying three hundred tons of ordnance. The convoy arrived at Quemoy and discharged its cargo without interference or incident. This good news was short-lived. A second convoy was caught in heavy fire; one cargo ship was abandoned aflame and the other withdrew. There was no shelling of the United States escort vessels, which were standing three miles offshore, as ordered. More convoys were planned, but the failure of the second one instantly created doubt in many quarters that the Communist "blockade by land gunfire" could be defeated. Failure followed failure for days, during which the feeling grew among both the Chinese and Americans on Formosa that the resupply situation was one that could scarcely be retrieved. Stores of food, medicines, and ammunition steadily dwindled.[7]

But the Chinese Nationalist sailors began to benefit from instruction in

[7] All accounts of supply levels varied. At one point they were said to consist of roughly fifty days' supply across the board, not a desperate situation but one which could easily become so if no more convoys could get through.

techniques known to the United States Navy, and they were becoming adept at handling specialized equipment that our forces had used so expertly in World War II. A particularly helpful item was the LVT, a tracked-landing, low-propelled vehicle designed to operate both in water and on land. The Nationalist Navy started to use these "swimming" trucks on September 14. Three days later, thirty-two LVTs transferred seventy-five hundred tons of cargo from the ships anchored three or four miles off the mainland and drove them right up onto the beaches of Quemoy. The next day Nationalist landing craft transported three 8-inch howitzers, particularly effective in counterbattery fire. Even junks were used in landing supplies as were, also, transport planes.[8] Sizes of daily deliveries grew. By the end of the month it appeared that air drop alone could maintain supply levels in essentials.

On October 5 the Communist Chinese, apparently admitting the failure of their efforts to subdue Quemoy by artillery fire, turned back to psychological warfare to try to split us from our ally. Their Defense Minister announced that Communist guns would cease firing for a week on Quemoy supply convoys if United States destroyers would cease to escort. The fire stopped, and United States vessels went back to normal patrolling of the Strait, ready to resume convoying if necessary.

The Nationalists took full advantage of the respite and on a single day unloaded nearly a twenty-day supply. On October 12 the Communist Defense Minister announced another suspension of firing for a period of two additional weeks.

With the temporary cease-fire, public support for our stand on the offshore islands issue rapidly developed. It was apparent that the Chinese Reds did not choose to precipitate a major war. So I made another attempt to convince the Generalissimo of the wisdom of reducing his garrisons on the islands. He finally did reduce them somewhat.

With this breathing space I thought it would be well for Secretary Dulles to have a serious talk with the Generalissimo. So Foster, after completing a visit in Rome, took the polar route to Formosa, though fearing that the Communists might make of his presence there an excuse to resume shelling the offshore islands. This they did, on October 16, but this could have been mere coincidence.

Foster's talks with the Generalissimo, held intermittently over a period

[8] In the aerial battles the Chinese Nationalists' fighter planes, some equipped with Sidewinder air-to-air missiles, took a heavy, one-sided toll against the Communist Air Force.

of three days, were most satisfactory. The Secretary, in order to dissipate the fears and anxieties created by Communist propaganda, emphasized the need for renouncing force as an acceptable means of regaining the mainland. The Communist propaganda theme, previously mentioned—namely, that Chiang was simply trying to involve the United States in a war with Communist China in order to gain the China mainland—had convinced many peoples and nations. Chiang's renunciation of aggressive force was therefore in his interest and ours.

The Generalissimo also accepted, in principle, the need for gradually developing better military arrangements for the offshore islands. Chiang did not say that he would start removing troops immediately, but indicated that discussions between his military people and ours would probably result in some redeployment, to Taiwan, of perhaps approximately fifteen thousand to twenty thousand men.

The Chinese Communists now suddenly announced that they would fire on Nationalist convoys only on odd days of the month, and would permit the Chinese Nationalists to resupply the offshore island garrisons on even-numbered days. I wondered if we were in a Gilbert and Sullivan war. In any event the Nationalists could easily build up any level of supply desired by simply shipping in all they desired every other day.

While saying nothing to Chiang, I expressed to our own military authorities the hope that he would continue to resupply on any day of his own choosing, to test the true intentions of the Communists. The shelling was costing them much more in expensive ammunition than it was accomplishing in material damage to the Nationalists. However, as a concession to the "terms" of this weird little war, the United States would not engage in any convoying operations unless the Chinese Communists attempted to interfere with the supply program on the even-numbered days in international waters.

Thus the crisis passed. The supply situation on the offshore islands was solved. The Chinese Communists, after issuing an astronomical number of "serious warnings" to the United States, gradually seemed to lose interest in Quemoy and Matsu and, except upon unusual or ceremonial occasions, ceased firing. The Nationalists reduced the size of their forces on the offshore islands, but not to the extent I thought desirable. The Chinese Communists have, as of this writing, refrained from reopening the issue by the use of force.